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COL-309201

Furrowed by Hooves

Igor: Don't look back.

Igor: Keep running. Don't look back.

Soldier, you're to hold position here.
And if you see any of our own turn to run ...

Take this rifle and shoot. Don't think.
Just shoot, like hunting a hare.

Igor: Yes, sir.

I believe in our men. Not a single soldier will step back.

Igor: Not a single soldier will step back.

His hands were always steady. It didn't matter if his sights were on a hare, a wild goose, the enemy, or his own comrades.

But the snow comes down in thick blankets. The icy flakes melt over his hands. He stifles a shiver.

Do not worry, Igor. They won't turn back.

No one turned back.

The soldier eases his finger off the trigger, wary of his skin sticking to the frozen metal.

Igor: ...!

Igor's finger twitches back to the cold metal as a figure enters his scope.

Forested Steppe

He had already seen that soldier.

That soldier had cloaked himself and his horse in the forest shadow, yet the moonlight reveals the glint of a badge on his cap.

Igor gives his own mount a firm pat. The roan red warhorse dips toward the water's edge.

Igor: At ease, soldier. This river's got enough for two horses.

Soldier: Yes, sir!

The soldier leads his horse to the river, halts before Igor, and salutes.

Soldier: Reporting! First Battalion, Cavalry Regiment.

Igor: Grigory Andreyevich. Cavalry Regiment Scout. I know.

A flush creeps up the soldier's face, making his crooked, high-bridged nose seem to curve like a saber.

Grigory: I didn't expect you'd know my name.

Igor: I remember. Your father is a Cossack from the Don.

War Horse: *neigh*

It's a beautiful white horse, groomed to perfection. The saddle shows no wear, silver trinkets glistening at the corners.

His colorful saddlebags seem more fit for celebration than the long road ahead.

And a long road it will be. After their brief rest following the Battle of Bereggrad, Igor's army must soon break camp.

But on the eve of departure, a soldier is leading his horse out. It goes against protocol.

Grigory: Sir, I know I shouldn't leave camp alone, but ...

Igor: I only came to water my horse, soldier.

He cuts the soldier off.

Igor: Take a good look at this river and the steppe.

Winter is closing in, and the air is thick with the decay of leaves and oak bark.

Feather grass stands tall in the steppes beyond the woody copse, glimmering with a soft silver light that suddenly bows low, tracing the wind's path.

Igor: You may have forgotten, but your father wouldn't.

Igor: This was my home once. I intend to see it for myself again before we leave.

Steady and patient, the river flows like deep green jade toward the distant Azov Sea.

Igor: A young Cossack like you probably wouldn't remember fishing here.

Grigory: I remember, sir.

The soldier speaks up. His tone is wistful, almost childlike, as if he's speaking to a brother, not his commanding officer.

Grigory: My father would take me fishing when I was small, always on nights with a full moon.

Grigory: I was too young to row, but Father didn't row much either. We just let the current take our boat wherever it willed.

Grigory: Father would toss a handful of rye into the water and cast his line out, then we'd sit under the moonlight for the rod to dip.

Grigory: The fish back then seemed to be as strong as bulls. We'd have to tire them out before bringing them in.

Grigory: I remember one catch, a good-sized catfish, with its puffing lips gasping as we pulled it out.

Grigory: He tossed it into my basket to carry home and said he'd be marching to the front tomorrow.

A ripple spreads on the water. Hearing their voices, the fish hide their shining scales.

Igor: Fish in the Don today, fight in the battlefield tomorrow. This is how we Cossacks live, child.

Igor's eyes don't linger on the water. Instead, he strides up to the white warhorse.

The horse lets out a spirited whinny, making a playful trot toward Igor's own horse, then turns back.

Igor: Your father taught you more than fishing, I see. This is a fine steed.

Grigory: I groom him daily and feed him oats and soymeal that I grind myself. He hates rye.

Igor: A true warhorse. Bred for the charge, not for hauling guns.

Igor takes the bridle. The white horse shakes its head and nudges his arm.

Igor: Hey. Good boy.

Igor meets the horse's black, glassy eyes.

Igor: He hasn't seen war yet. Do you think he can handle the battlefield?

Grigory: Sir, how can you tell he hasn't fought?

Igor: There's a look in his eyes. Horses and men are alike in that way.

Igor: He reminds me of the stories of Perun.

Grigory: Perun?

Igor whistles. The tall, red horse tosses its mane and comes to him.

Igor: Perun, the thunder god. A comrade named him that, because he runs like thunder. But even Perun once feared the sound of gunfire.

Grigory: Did he?

Grigory: Not so much anymore, eh, boy?

Grigory gazes up at the tall warhorse with clear admiration.

Grigory: I've seen him often in the stables. You always keep him close.

He pats Perun's neck. The horse doesn't shy away.

Grigory: How old is he?

Igor: Nearing 20. Almost time to retire.

Grigory: But he's splendid. When did he first see war?

Igor: That was 15 years ago.

Fifteen years ago, before Igor became Admiral Igor.

Before the "Storm."

Field, Steppe

The horses have finished drinking. The Big Dipper hangs just above the horizon.

Igor mounts. He looks over the ready white horse and the soldier holding its reins.

Igor: Are we going the same way?

Grigory pulls his cap lower. The brim shadows his eyes.

Grigory: Perhaps we are, sir.

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COL-309202

Righteous Sacrifices

Command Post, Al Muntar

1995, Al Muntar. Zeno's 9th Division. Officers sit in a ring in the yard of the temporary command post.

There are no chairs. They sit on straw or hard earth, past concern for comfort. Their coats are stiff with dried blood and dirt.

Officer I: You didn't see what I saw. That gunner I pulled out of the car—his eyes were leaking oil.

Officer II: Who knows what we're fighting? Air defense is dead. Can't get a scout plane up.

Officer III: It seems almost like how things were in the Great Patriotic War.

Officer II: And what did we fight then? German tanks, 800 mm guns, and bears the size of three men.

Officer I: Better than dealing with these monsters.

Igor: Arseny, what's the situation?

Arseny: We fell back in good order. We minimized casualties to below expectations. Less than thirty percent.

Arseny: But the armored corps is gone. The tanks are all stopped dead out there. Only half the crews made it back.

Arseny: They've outclassed our armor entirely. But what's pinning us down isn't their tech. It's their arcane skills.

Igor: I know.

Igor: Have whatever's left of the armored corps placed into the infantry companies. Give them whatever rifles and ammunition we can spare.

Igor: Tonight, the guards will bring in all our dead. We will need more space for graves.

Arseny nods.

Silence settles over the yard, layer upon layer like dust.

The sound of spraying water comes from the stables. A stream of mud, blood, and oil flows down from the bright chestnut coat of a horse.

Officer I: Andrea. How can you still be in the mood to fuss over a horse at a time like this?

Officer II: Old Crooked Nose babying his precious Perun again, what's new?

Officer III: What good's a beast of flesh and bone against tungsten and steel?

Andrea circles around Perun, checking him diligently for wounds, before wheeling to face his jeering comrades.

Andrea: You'd have a Cossack go without his horse? You forget there are places a tank is not fit to go.

Andrea: Mountains, forests, swamps, city streets ... Where tanks will go, I take a tank. But where they cannot, Perun will go.

Arseny: Day drinking again, Andrea?

Andrea ignores him. He places his hands on the fence, his burly frame clearing it smoothly.

Mid-descent, he thrusts his riding whip toward the sky.

Andrea: Our plan is simple! We ride forward and cut down everyone in our path with our shashkas!

Andrea: All we need to do is ride faster than their bullets!

The gathered officers laugh. It's almost enough to break the tension in the air.

Igor laughs, too.

Andrea: Igor, sir, not you too. It was your plan!

Igor: It was my plan. But your horse was too slow. The bullets caught you.

Officer I: That's how that nose of yours got bent out of shape, wasn't it!

The crooked-nosed man raises his whip, making a herding call.

Andrea: Shoo, shoo! I was born with this proud feature. As was my grandfather and his before him.

Igor: It wasn't a bullet that caused that damage anyways.

Igor: In the fight, this one pulled a shovel out of nowhere, held it overhead, and the bullet just bounced off.

The laughter grows louder, becoming like a steady ripple, at last piercing through the air.

Igor's adjutant comes close, voice low beneath the laughter.

Adjutant: Sir, the Pax House.

The Pax House's communicator is different from Zeno's red phone.

It is white, clean, like a pebble from the Don. Normally, it is just as quiet.

Igor: Our radar remains nonfunctional. Air defense and armor systems are paralyzed. Cause unknown.

Igor: Initial assessment points to arcanist activity. Not a single arcane soldier's power, but an elaborate ritual.

Igor: We need heavier fire support. We will also need a dedicated arcanist detachment.

The request meets a long static hum. Vice Admiral Igor stands straight, holding stiffly by the communicator, waiting with perfect detachment.

A young voice comes through, cool and even.

Communicator: "The Pax House acknowledges your loyalty for not withdrawing without orders under these conditions."

Igor: My army will keep marching until the order comes.

Communicator: "We salute your efforts. Reinforcements are on the way."

Igor: I need an ETA.

Communicator: "Not available. We can confirm they are already en route. Until they arrive, you must hold Al Muntar."

Communicator: "Whatever it takes."

The flat voice rises to stress these last words, pressing the unspoken gravity of the situation.

Communicator: "Have you further questions?"

Igor: One more.

Igor: What is in this city?

Communicator: "..."

Igor: Our orders are to hold Al Muntar at all costs. And the enemy, despite achieving total air superiority, has refused to commit their bombers to the assault.

Igor: Something here matters to both sides. What is it?

Communicator: "Any specifics are on a need-to-know basis. You don't have the clearance, sorry."

Communicator: "You have your orders."

Communicator: "Good luck, Vice Admiral."

Al Muntar looks no different from other cities he has known.

Igor studies the map rolled out on the table. His finger points toward the city center.

Igor: High ground.

His finger moves past the old fort and the bank, sketching the city's form in the dry air.

Igor: Forest.

The city clings to the mountain, ringed by dry juniper forests and, below them, rain-drenched wadis.

Igor: Plains.

Just beyond lie the wide scrublands where his army first met their mysterious enemy. He marks down the results: 30% casualties, armored corps effectively destroyed.

Igor: Like being dragged back fifty years, back to the Great Patriotic War.

Igor was not born then, but the war still left its mark on him—his father, Vasily, was a cavalry officer in that war.

Vasily: "Tanks are tougher than horses. But tanks cannot go everywhere. Horses can."

Igor: Forests, swamps, streets, ruins.

Vasily: "In such places, their armor and firepower mean little. Once the enemy is forced out from their iron shell ..."

Igor: It is soldier against soldier.

Vasily: "Our men are no better at street fighting. But we fear death less."

Igor: My army fears no enemy.

Vasily: "Haha! Forget hundreds of meters. In a city, you fight for three or five at a time. You might fight for control of a single room."

Vasily: "We fought from the living room to the kitchen. The next day, back the other way. Lost three men for the kitchen, and we held it less than a day."

Vasily: "But it wasn't a bad trade. Those bastards lost seven over the living room. And we took out their tank with a few Molotovs."

Vasily: "Soldiers' lives were traded for hours. We were three hundred strong when we arrived. We bought a day and a half."

Vasily: "My commander called it the best deal that war could offer."

Igor: ...

Igor measures the streets in his head, counting the hours he can buy, the lives he can spend to hold out until reinforcements arrive.

Igor: Perhaps reinforcements will arrive tomorrow.

Igor: Or perhaps Death intends to visit us earlier.

He shakes his head. Not at the conclusion, but at his own hesitation.

A bullet, once fired, does not hesitate.

There has only ever been one order.

Igor returns to the yard, where Andrea has Perun saddled and ready.

His new leather saddle is riddled with silver trinkets fastened to the corners. A beautiful thing that seems out of place in a warzone.

Andrea isn't alone. Each of his officers leads out their own warhorse.

Although long absent from the charge, the horses are well maintained, their coats sleek and their legs strong.

War Horse: *neigh*

The excited whinnies of the horses fill the yard, but the riders atop them are silent as they look to Igor with matching grim faces.

A wordless acknowledgement passes from officers to commander and back again.

Their orders have not changed.

Igor: Hold this place until reinforcement comes.

Igor: Whatever it takes.

Officers: Yes, sir!

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COL-309203

Fill the First Cup

Field, Steppe

Igor takes the reins, his eyes narrowing as he stares up toward the North Star through reddened and weary eyes.

Since arriving on the steppes—no, since leaving São Paulo—he has not slept a full night.

The black-violet night surrounds him. He leads no army now and follows no orders. He simply rides toward the North Star.

Villager: ♫ My little horse and I, we ride through the golden fields beneath the sky. How sorrowfully my heart sighs. ♫

A song drifts along from the river, giving the night a sudden peace and life.

Grigory: ♫ I hear the wind whispering on and on. ♫

A low, murmured hum finds the quiet soldier. Heartened by the singing across the water, it grows clearer.

Grigory: ♫ I hear the river singing me a song, as if trying to say ... ♫

His face may be overcast, but his singing is as bright and clear as the moon.

Igor: ♫ The river is trying to say, "The boy will never come back home from far away." ♫

Igor: Who taught you that song?

Grigory: My grandfather taught my father, sir, and my father taught me.

Grigory: Though he only managed to teach me this one song.

Igor: You're a man of many talents, Grigory.

Grigory: Thank you, sir. I never would've expected that you sing as well.

The soldier's surprise is plain. His face softens, just as his voice did.

Igor: There is no Cossack who cannot sing.

Igor: In the old days, after a hard-won victory, we would sing that very song. Who knows how old it truly is?

Igor: ♫ The Black Sea's waves rise high. Warships light up the night. ♫

Igor: ♫ Douse the lamps, sink the boats. Cossack honor will never die! ♫

The rhythmic tune taps a rhythm against the air.

Igor: That song reminds me of the prisiadka dance. Do you know the steps?

Grigory: Put a gun to my head, sir, and I still wouldn't know my left foot from my right. At least when it comes to dancing.

Igor: Then it's not just your father's nose that scares off the ladies, is it?

Igor laughs, catching the poor soldier off-guard, but soon after, the laughter is returned, only ended by a sudden chill in the night air.

Cold as the night before a battle.

Igor: A true Cossack doesn't hold back his thoughts. Listen to his song, and you know his heart.

Igor: If the next day's fight looks grim, we drink ourselves into a stupor and sing that song.

The admiral breathes the crisp air deep into his chest.

Igor: ♫ Cold wind blows beyond the hill. So sharp it silenced the birds' trill. Trees shiver in the winter's chill. ♫

Igor: ♫ Through the winter night snow falls low, where lies a thick shroud made of snow. A Cossack's bones lie deep below. ♫

Al Muntar

Officers: ♫ ... made of snow. A Cossack's bones lie deep below. With his last breath, the Cossack pleads. Build him a high grave mound where he can be laid. ♫

Officers: ♫ Like the soil of the homeland he used to know, where bright red hydrangeas shall grow. ♫

Andrea: Care to make a wager, Arseny?

Arseny: There is no roulette wheel here to bet on. Except the cylinder of your handgun.

Andrea: Bah, I gave up on revolvers ages ago. I won't be picking a number between one and six.

Andrea: Here. Before a fight, I always flip a coin.

Arseny takes the coin, its back showing a woman bearing a sword with arms wide, and its front showing its value.

A one-ruble commemorative coin, proudly stamped with an image of the Great Patriotic War's most famous monument.

Andrea: The old flags are gone. Yet here we are, fighting over new ones.

Arseny holds the coin up to the dark sky and blows on it.

Arseny: You'd let a ruble decide your fate? Go home, old man. You're better off farming than fighting.

Andrea: I have long wished to trade in this gun for a scythe.

Arseny smiles, tosses the coin high, catches it, and covers it on the back of his hand.

Andrea: Let me see. Heads. You lucky dog.

Andrea: The coin says you keep your head tomorrow.

Arseny: And you? Heads or tails?

Andrea: I always got heads before. This fearsome nose of mine wards off bad luck.

Andrea: Unlike poor Igor. Always tails.

Igor: Death follows me the way fleas follow you.

Igor: But at a distance.

They rarely drink before battle now. Tonight is an exception. They know what they face tomorrow.

The vice admiral's cup is filled and emptied again and again. He drinks with every man more than once.

But his mind stays clear, his sight as keen as an eagle's.

Igor: Every man still here has a stiff neck and a thick skull. Thankfully, Death's scythe is dull. It will break before it cuts through even one of you.

Igor's gaze, hot from the fire, passes over each officer.

Igor: Hold your ground, obey your orders. I give you my word, victory will be ours.

Igor: As always.

Officer I: Comrades! To Victory!

Officer II: Let's beat those monsters back to hell!

Officer III: See the bank in the middle of the street? Tomorrow I'll hold that door myself. Not a soul gets through. Safe enough to take a hot bath!

Each officer stakes a claim over their sectors, boasting over who might spill the most enemy blood.

Arseny: And the high ground?

Arseny points toward the raised overlook at the center of town, like the exposed spine of a slumbering beast.

The commanding view over the city is an obvious prize and likely to be the measure of victory or defeat.

By tomorrow's end, that hilltop would climb higher still, raised on the corpses of the fallen.

Arseny: We'll need an entire regiment up there if we have any hope of holding it.

The talk and laughter stop. The fire seems to quiet, too.

Igor: No need for a regiment. It will only take one man.

Arseny pauses, the drink flushing from his red face to his eyes. He pats Igor on his shoulder.

Arseny: I should have known it would be you.

He raises his cup high.

Arseny: To Igor!

Officers: To Igor!

His saber catches the firelight, making its edge resemble a burning crescent moon.

Igor wipes his shashka, from the eagle-headed brass hilt to the elegant, fierce sweep of the blade.

Golden liquor splashes onto the steel.

Andrea: Hey! To Igor!

Igor takes the cup from Andrea's hand.

The singing is done, and the cups are empty. Around them, men begin to snore.

Igor: You hold your drink better than you used to.

Andrea: Old Andrea gets drunk only when he wants.

Andrea: But I say better to ride into battle fuzzy than clear.

Andrea: Better to forget the danger, to forget that I am only flesh and blood, not a blade.

Andrea: Yet, tomorrow I wish to have a clear mind. The clearer, the better.

Igor: Why?

Andrea: You should know why. You never get drunk before a fight.

Igor: A commander needs to think and see clearly.

Andrea: Yes. See how the men mount up, how they form their line, and how they cut the enemy down like beets.

Andrea: See how they march and ride toward their deaths.

Igor: This is war.

Andrea matches Igor's eyes for a second, locked in certain shared knowledge.

Andrea: But this is no ordinary war. Our enemies are different. We have more to worry about than tanks and machine guns.

Andrea: Arcane weapons we could never have imagined. You saw them in action. It was worse than a bomb. Men turned to vapor, not even a body left to bury.

Igor: From the day we chose this path, we knew the stakes. Men die in war. In the end, we must accept our own deaths too.

Andrea: And what are we dying for? What if all of this is for nothing?

Andrea: Look at this city. A soldier may live only a day here, an officer three. Why do we ask these boys to die for it? We're only here for one reason.

Andrea: Because we believe in you, Igor.

Andrea: Even among the officers, we cannot help but believe. They think you can take the very scythe from Death's hands.

Andrea: That you will pluck victory from the maw of hell itself.

Igor: Because I will. Whether the enemy be the devil or death itself, I will.

Igor: I will be the last defense for every one of you.

Andrea: I have no doubt, commander. I have never doubted you, not since the first day we bled together.

Andrea: But in all of this fighting, all of this blood, we're only the blade, not the hand that wields it.

Andrea: That hand hides behind a communicator. They count the losses of war as numbers on a graph, not the faces of dying boys.

Andrea: They are more than names waiting to be carved into the Hall of Merit.

Andrea: What do we fight for? Whose orders do we even follow?

Igor: We swore an oath: Obedient, loyal, unwavering.

Andrea faces Igor eye-to-eye. The laughter is gone from his face. Every wrinkle of age holds taut like a stretched rubber band.

Every line is tight, ready to break.

Andrea: I won't be the only one asking these questions tonight.

Andrea: No man rides into the jaws of death without a reason. No man.

The old soldier says the words softly, like a silver thread the wind might blow away.

But Igor hears it as loud as thunder.

He looks down, his eyes fixed on his cup.

Igor: You've had too much to drink.

Igor: When morning comes, you will forget these words. So will I.

Andrea looks at him a moment, then the strength leaves him. His shoulders sink like earth worn down by shells.

Andrea: I am drunk.

Andrea picks up his empty cup and steps back into the dark beyond the fire.

Igor: Andrea!

Igor: We have barrier troops at the rear. They'll shoot anyone who runs.

Igor: You know this. If you run, a bullet goes right between your eyes.

Igor: I won't bend protocol for you.

Andrea nods, smiling as he points his finger to his temple like a gun.

Andrea: Bang!

[English text unavailable]

COL-309204

Harder than Armor

Steppe Farmhouse

Farmer: Bang! The bullet came that close to my skull.

Farmer: I felt it glide over my nose, then skip away, as if my nose were made of solid iron.

Grigory: Couldn't really be iron, could it? Too crooked, like mine.

Farmer: Wait till you have a taste of real battle, lad; you'll see. Doesn't matter how straight you shoot. If God has written your name on a bullet, it will find you. Life and death are in His hands.

The two horses eat grass in the yard. True to Cossack hospitality, the farmer has offered all that he can to his guests.

Farmer: Have some water, sir.

Igor: Thank you.

Igor: You served then, old man?

Farmer: You know us Cossacks. We mount our horses to fight and dismount to cut our wheat. What a beautiful horse! But you must be an officer to own a horse so fine.

Farmer: I only have just the one now, a burly gray thing, lame now. I broke his leg myself. So, he wouldn't be taken by the Tsar and sent to die on the front.

Farmer: He was a fine horse, too.

Igor: At least he still has your yard.

Grigory: Thank you for the kindness and your fodder, sir.

Farmer: Don't thank me. Give thanks to our Lord. It was His mercy that spared you and brought you past my house tonight.

Farmer: Take this icon, young man. Sew it inside your collar.

The farmer lays his calloused, dry hand on Grigory's head. The soldier bows it lightly.

Farmer: Let this golden shield guard you. Your faith shall be your armor, your flesh like iron.

Farmer: Even bullets will not dare to scratch you.

Grigory: I'd rather they never find me in the first place.

Igor: Do you believe in God?

On the white horse a length behind, the soldier is tying the icon next to the cross at his chest.

He pauses a moment, then smiles bashfully.

Grigory: I don't know, sir. My grandmother gave me the cross. She sewed these icons inside the collars for my father and me.

Igor: Perhaps they hold some power.

Grigory: Is there one sewn into your uniform?

Igor: There is. My grandmother was a faithful woman. There were icons in my pockets, in my shirts, my father's and mine.

Igor: She believed it was those stitches that brought my father home from Stalingrad.

Igor: And that I survived every time my rifle pinged dry.

Al Muntar

A single man stands upon the high ground of Al Muntar.

His ammunition gone, Igor holds his shashka. The thin blade is rolled and chipped all along the damaged edge.

Piles of bodies lie beneath his boots, so many they blanket the earth.

Communicator: "Reinforcements are here. Launch the counterattack now."

The vice admiral doesn't answer.

He looks up into the sky. A dark shadow wheels above—not a plane, but a vulture.

It's waiting for the king of the hill to fall.

Igor: I see no reinforcements. Only dead men. Mine and theirs.

Communicator: "The 9th Division is to launch a counterattack at once."

Communicator: "We will honor your forces and every soldier that falls. When this battle is done, you will be raised to the rank of Admiral."

Communicator: "But these are your orders."

Igor: I have only one question.

Igor: What is in this city?

Communicator: "It isn't mission-relevant for you to know."

Communicator: "Believe that every drop of blood shed by your men will water a new world of peace and order."

Communicator: "Every sacrifice is necessary, but we can't say anything more."

Igor: What is in this city?

The silence from the other end feels like a sigh.

Communicator: "Operation's specifics are above your clearance level, sir."

Igor: We will do as ordered. We will fight and we will die until the end.

Igor: But I WILL know what we are fighting for.

Igor walks down from the high ground into the street.

Blood trickles down the road like a lush spring. Spent casings rustle under his feet with each step, like the fallen leaves in the birch woods near his home.

His father used to spar with him there, teaching him to use the shashka.

Vasily: "In close quarters, a blade is swifter than a rifle."

Vasily: "Hold it. Feel its balance. Make no unnecessary movements. The blade will tell you when the moment is."

Now.

Igor holds the shashka with a backhand grip, cutting a sharp, clean arc across an enemy soldier.

The masked soldier falls like a wet sack, black slime seeping from the gash in his abdomen.

Enemy Soldier: —!!

Igor appears behind another enemy as if from nowhere, driving his shashka through their back.

It is his arcane skill. He can traverse the underworld, delivering death from unexpected angles.

Vasily: "On the battlefield, you need to watch for more than just men. Listen for the whir of shells. A long sound means it's still far off."

Vasily: "A low, urgent puff means it is right above you."

Igor hears it.

Igor: Lie down!!

The shell strikes the bank dead on.

The commander of his 1st Regiment, a man who enjoys nothing more than a hot bath, stands with his mouth hanging open with a look of puzzled bewilderment.

Until a cloud of dust and rubble blurs his face.

Vasily: "An army wins only if it acts as one body."

Vasily: "Every cell must work together, without question or hesitation. That is how the whole survives."

Vasily: "At Stalingrad, I traded 300 men for 300 meters of ground."

Here it seems they've fallen even thicker and for less.

Igor knows every face. The living and the lost.

Nikolai from the 1st Battalion lies on his face. His cap is gone along with the top of his skull, the inside of which is filled with a strange, squirming black slime.

Young Karimov, dissolved by some kind of arcane skill. His blue eyes melted like runny eggs streaking over his nose; his fingers clutch the barrel of his rifle, which has somehow been forced through his own gut.

Igor: Pyotor with the nicked ear. Dmitri, who stopped a missile with a potato sack ...

Igor: Then that damned crooked nose.

Andrea is thankfully whole. Two soldiers carry him by the head and boots, as if he were only sleeping off a hangover.

A single bloody hole in his forehead.

He knows this shape.

Arseny: Seven deserters. Handled as the code demands.

Seven. For a battle this bitter, it is little surprise. The fear of death can break even the strongest soldier if they lose hope. Every commander knows that.

A hollow tremor passes through Igor's chest.

Arseny: Perun ... He bolted toward our line. Spooked by the sound of gunfire, perhaps.

Arseny: No one knows what Andrea was thinking then.

Igor: I see.

He pats Arseny on his shoulder and continues toward the front.

Yes, this has happened before. It will happen again. It is protocol. Necessary. Now, always.

A river of red runs at his feet. A hail of bullets falls from above.

And yet, through it all, he hears that song again, softly rising from hoarse throats:

Officers: ♫ With his last breath, the Cossack pleads. Build him a high grave mound where he'll be laid. ♫

Officers: ♫ Like the soil of the homeland he used to know, where bright red hydrangeas shall grow. ♫

[English text unavailable]

COL-309205

The Prisoner of Honor

Grigory: That old man's nose. It's nearly identical to my father's.

The white horse prances forward a few steps, matching Perun's pace. The soldier's voice reaches Igor, clear and sharp.

Grigory: He went off to serve and never came home. All we got was a medal and a letter, saying he fell in battle.

Grigory: He was never a man for proper prayers. Those little stitches didn't do much to help him.

Grigory: Grandmother would always say how much I take after him. I mean, the crooked nose. She prays every day I don't inherit his bad luck.

Perun throws his head up and snorts.

Igor: Steady now, boy.

Igor bends forward, giving the red horse's neck a pat.

Igor: Your father was a good soldier.

Grigory: I know it, sir. It's why I signed up.

Igor: When I was young, I wanted to be the soldier my father was.

Igor: Some children are raised with fairy tales. My father would tell me stories of Stalingrad.

Igor: Every street, every building, every person in that city—living or dead—they're all here.

Igor points to his head.

Igor: Clearer than any other memory from my childhood.

Grigory: I suppose it made you who you are today.

The admiral does not answer right away. He looks down, thinking for a moment.

Igor: He taught me to ride, to shoot bottles from the air, to strike an enemy on the left as you pass.

Igor: He taught me everything a soldier should know.

Igor tightens the reins, leaning back a little. Perun feels it and slows down.

Igor: But the truth is, I couldn't say if he was a good soldier.

Forested Steppe

A row of bottles are laid out on the ground, partially buried in falling birch leaves.

Igor: Steady, smooth ...

The young man places his finger on the trigger, draws a breath, and lets it out slowly. In the quiet moment after the exhale, the shooter's body is at its most stable.

Now—

???: On me! All fighters! Charge—

A heavy thump comes from behind. At the same moment, the bottles hit the ground and break with sharp cracks.

Igor: Father. Vasily!

The young man sets the rifle down and pulls his drunken father up.

It was never easy. Vasily is a mountain of a man, and in his stupor, he is like a wild animal, bucking and flailing his arms.

Vasily: Throw Molotovs at their tanks! Well done!

He shakes Igor's hand and stands straight with a fierce, fiery look in his eyes.

Vasily: Yegor pins the heavy guns from the roof! Valeri takes the ground floor!

Vasily: Explosives ... The demolition team ... Where are they?!

Igor: You shouldn't drink like this anymore.

His father does not hear him. He spins around, listening for an explosion that has not come. Only the wind rustles through the birch leaves.

A mist clouds Vasily's dull eyes.

Vasily: Yegor ... He fell from the roof. I couldn't get to his body.

Vasily: And my gun, it's empty, damn it! Where is my gun?

Igor: You shouldn't be handling a gun right now. You couldn't even hold it steady.

Vasily: Bullsh**t. I took down fifty men with that rifle. I held the line.

Vasily: My gun's gone. I can't ... I can't go on. Death is staring at me. It's so cold.

Vasily: Lord, have mercy on your humble servant. His cold, stiff fingers can't even clasp together.

Vasily: Vodka. Where's the vodka?

He falls to his knees, letting his face plow into the dirt, rotting leaves, and shattered glass below him.

But the vodka has long soaked away into the leaves and the cold earth beneath.

Igor: Vasily!

The young man yanks his father upright by his collar.

Igor: Are you a soldier or not?!

Igor: Is this a cavalry commander before me? Have you lost all your nerve, Father?

Vasily shakes his head, forcing his swollen eyes open, trying to see the figure in front of him.

Vasily: You don't understand. You have not seen war as I have. You know nothing, boy.

Igor: I'm going to the front tomorrow!

Igor: Tomorrow, I will see what you have. I will be the first man forward. No matter who my enemy is.

Igor: And if I were to look back, if I were to hesitate for even a moment, I'd rather be shot by my own comrades than become you!

Vasily's eyes finally open fully. He looks at the young man, who shares the same gray eyes.

Vasily: Do you know the smell of burning flesh?

Vasily: It is strangely sweet. But breathe it in for just a moment, and it sticks in your nose, your throat. You cannot clear it. You carry that smell to your grave.

Vasily: Do you know the sound of a bone breaking?

Vasily: It's a sharp snap, like pulling down a frozen branch, like ice cracking.

Vasily: You do not know, boy. You don't understand.

The young man stands unmoved and unbroken by his father's reproach.

Igor: Yes. I don't know. But I will. And when I do, I will not take one step back.

Igor: I will win. Whether my enemy be the devil or death itself.

Vasily: So brave, so stupid! Another young man destined for death.

The drunkard still doesn't seem to even recognize his own son.

He steps back, squinting at the young man who stands proud and sturdy like an oak and at the rifle in his hands.

Then he grins.

Vasily: Let me teach you the secret to winning, then.

Vasily: You must fear death, boy.

Vasily: Not just your own. You must fear the death of every man.

[English text unavailable]

COL-309206

The Living and the Dead

Igor: I had my sights on a hare. I asked the commander, "What do I do now?"

Igor: He told me I was a good shot. Told me not to move; to stand my ground. And if any of our own ran back, to shoot them with my rifle.

Igor: Like hunting a hare.

A rough laugh escapes Igor. The soldier replies.

Grigory: I wanted to run away. The first time.

Grigory: But I knew there was no turning back. If I ran, I'd end up with a bullet through my head. But if I pushed onward, I at least had a chance.

Grigory: So I just kept going. That fight through that snowy mountain pass, you remember it?

Igor: I remember ...

Grigory: I got knocked off the cliff in the first few minutes. They left me hanging there until your flight unit saved me.

Grigory: I'm not a proper soldier, sir. I could never be like you.

Igor: In the last battle, I saw that you were the first to storm the enemy's position. You've done well.

Grigory looks at Igor, surprised. A genuine grin spreads across his face.

Grigory: Thank you, sir.

Grigory: I know you don't say those things lightly. I think every soldier under your command would want nothing more than to hear that we've done well.

Grigory: Every one of us wanted to be like you, sir. That was our second wish.

Grigory: The first was to have our names carved in the Hall of Merit at headquarters.

Grigory: But the more battles I fight, the less I understand why I'm fighting.

Grigory: The friends I joined up with are all gone. On that mountain, at the South Pole, in São Paulo ...

Grigory: Maybe their names are carved into that hall now, but I'm not sure I would have the heart to look.

His voice catches in his throat. He hesitates over his next words.

But he turns anyway and meets the admiral's gaze.

Grigory: What about your friends, sir?

Zeno Headquarters

The losses were so great that Zeno headquarters was forced to expand the Hall of Merit in 1999.

Most of Zeno's fallen are marked by only a name on the wall.

Yet Igor sees a face behind each one.

Administrative Staff Member: Sorry to keep you waiting, Admiral.

Administrative Staff Member: But the files you requested regarding the Battle of Al Muntar in 1995 are not yet declassified. Unfortunately, they're ...

Igor: Above my clearance level. Correct?

The staff member gives a polite, apologetic smile, choosing the words carefully.

Administrative Staff Member: The thing is, there were many such smaller engagements in 1995. It can be difficult to keep track of every archive and file.

Administrative Staff Member: And as I'm sure you're aware, headquarters is still sorting through the aftermath of the recent battle. Things here are even more disorganized.

Igor: I understand.

Administrative Staff Member: Thank you, and thank you for your service to Zeno. Can I help you with anything else?

Igor: In the third row, sixth column, for 1995, you've mixed up Nikolai's and Dmitri's last names.

Igor: Please, have it fixed. Those two never got along.

Administrative Staff Member: What?

The staff member puzzles over his words for a moment before settling back into the professional and well-polished smile.

Administrative Staff Member: Apologies for the mistake, sir. I'll make certain it's corrected.

Igor: Thank you.

The admiral turns and leaves. The door closed behind him.

Hall of Merit, Zeno

He walks along the names in the Hall of Merit, from 1995 to 1999.

The losses of 1999 occupy an entire wall of their own.

A girl with black hair stands before the wall. She is still small, not yet the daring lieutenant she would one day be, and has to tilt her head back to see her parents' faces, given the rare honor of a portrait.

Igor: Moldir.

Moldir: Admir ... Father.

Igor: You may call me Admiral. Or Igor, if you would like.

It is his first day with his new foster daughter. He stands beside her, looking at the photo of his comrade.

Igor: Arseny. He fell in 1999, in Abadan.

Igor: It's a good picture.

Igor: We knew these photos would end up here one day. He made sure to dress for it.

Igor: I told him to shave that beard.

Igor: He told me, "You're one to talk."

Moldir turns, studying her new foster father's face, from his forehead to his jaw.

Then she nods.

Igor: You are his daughter, indeed.

Moldir: I never imagined there would be so many names.

Igor: There were fewer when we started.

Igor: I came here on my first day with Zeno. That day, I decided that I would not rest until my name was carved alongside the others.

Moldir: Did that make you proud?

Igor pauses.

Igor: At that time. We believed we were fighting to bring peace and order to the world.

Igor: We thought a soldier's courage could tame this mad world, like breaking a wild horse.

Moldir: So my mother and father, they were proud, too.

It isn't a question, but Igor nods anyway.

Igor: They earned a soldier's honor.

Moldir: Will my name be here one day?

Igor bends down a little, meeting Moldir's gaze.

Igor: You would not be the first to wish for it. But I hope not to see that day.

Igor: Do you want a soldier's honor, like your parents?

The girl looks up at the wall, at the thousands of names stretching out like a vast web, hanging over the shoulders of the living.

She doesn't understand war yet. She couldn't possibly answer his question.

But there is one thing she needs to know first.

Moldir: All these people ... Why did they die?

Igor: Because ...

There are many answers. They died in the Battle of the "Storm." They died by Manus Vindictae's hand. They died to push back chaos and evil. They died fighting for peace.

He lets his gaze wander across the length of the Hall, where names stretch back from 1999 to the founding of Zeno.

Countless names broken up by countless doors. Each time he comes here, he sees them open and close.

Administrative Staff Member: "The files you requested regarding the Battle of Al Muntar in 1995 are not yet declassified."

Communicator: "Believe that every drop of blood shed by your men will water a new world of peace and order."

Administrative Staff Member: "Sir, you don't have the clearance."

Communicator: "Every sacrifice is necessary, but we can't say anything more."

Administrative Staff Member: "Sorry."

The admiral stands before the 1999 "Storm" wall, looking at the young, familiar faces. He can't bring himself to answer Moldir's question.

Igor: I don't know.

Igor: But I will find an answer.

[English text unavailable]

COL-309207

Lingering No More

The admiral and the soldier pause at the river's edge.

Winter has been late to arrive, but when it came, it spread fast and fierce, turning the river's surface into brittle ice.

Grigory: This won't be thick enough. A few days from now, when the ice is solid, the horses can walk right over.

Igor: Some ice looks as solid as concrete until a hoof goes through.

Igor: My father lost a sled horse that way.

Grigory: The elders in my village used to say the same. The roads on the river seem wide, but not every path is safe.

Igor: Correct.

Igor: In times like these, we must choose our path carefully.

The horses stamp softly by the river's edge. The vast steppe stretches out beyond its curve, many paths still open to the riders.

Igor: Are we still going the same way, soldier?

The soldier exhales, letting the cloud of his breath obscure his face, as if to hide his thoughts.

Grigory: Perhaps we are not, sir.

A river mist hangs in the night, drifting like a silver veil over the forest.

Igor: Where are you going? The White Army? The Red Army? Manus Vindictae?

Grigory: I'm not staying right here, sir. I know there isn't anywhere to run. You've already seen me.

Igor: A soldier's doubts always show on his face.

Igor: You have access to command information, so someone is always watching you.

Grigory: I never wanted to run to Manus Vindictae. I don't want a mask. I won't become one of those monsters.

Igor: I know.

Igor: You fought well last time. There's a ceremony before we break camp. Tomorrow, you'll receive a promotion and a medal of honor.

Grigory: It isn't a medal that I want, sir. I don't want to see my name carved into that wall.

Grigory: Once, maybe. Not anymore.

Igor: What do you want, soldier?

Grigory: I suppose ... I just ...

A faint breeze stirs, light as the brush of a nightingale's wing.

Grigory: I just want to go home. I want to be home.

The wind picks up, carrying the scent of dry mugwort and thyme across the steppe.

Grigory: At first, I thought I hadn't changed. But with every battle, I feel as though my heart freezes a little more. Like ice forming over the Don.

Grigory: Nothing causes a ripple in me anymore. Fear, anger, and grief—they just slide away.

Grigory: All I ever wanted was to be honored in that hall. I thought that's where I'd finally find my rest.

Grigory: But now, being here, I want something else. I don't want to be a soldier remembered on a wall.

Igor watches the lilac mist part, the wind carving a path through the fog to the white birch forest beyond.

Igor: This place holds all that remains of our past.

Igor: But the past is the past, son. This era is ending.

Igor: But not my army. I will lead you through the fire and the "Storm."

Igor: We will exist no matter what may change in the coming era. We will be an army for all of time.

Grigory: Do we have a choice?

Igor doesn't answer.

The steppe feels utterly silent. Golden stars, unable to bear the silence, start to fall into the dawn.

Grigory: I don't want to die fighting for a city of strangers, sir, or fall in some cold wasteland in Antarctica. I want to die here in the soil of my motherland.

Not everyone wishes to board this Ark.

Grigory: My name isn't fit for the Hall of Merit. I will dig a small grave on the steppe.

Grigory: And the next year, red hydrangeas will bloom where I sleep.

Igor: You know, I have never accepted desertion from my ranks.

Grigory: I know.

Grigory dismounts, stands tall, and meets Igor's gaze. His young back is straight and solid.

Igor: How fast can your horse run?

Grigory: Fast as dry lightning on the spring steppe.

Igor: Then mount up, son. Ride as fast as you can.

Grigory's face grows serious. He knows what is coming.

But the shadow lifts from his face, slowly replaced by a full and beaming smile.

The soldier adjusts his cap.

Grigory: I salute you, sir!

The wind rustles the tall feather grass as Grigory swings into the saddle.

Grigory: Run, old friend. Outpace the bullet this time.

The white horse races toward the line where the steppe meets the night sky. At the far edge of sight, a faint, mythical blue light shimmers.

Igor raises his rifle. His right index finger finds the trigger. His hands are steady, the pressure even.

Breathe in. Breathe out. Hold.

Bang!

The bullet scrapes over the top of the soldier's head, knocking his military cap off.

Igor: "Let this golden shield guard you. Your faith shall be your armor, your flesh like iron."

Igor: "Even bullets will not dare to scratch you."

The white horse runs on, faster and faster, into the dreamy blue light.

Igor hadn't aimed for the soldier's head.

[English text unavailable]

COL-309208

An Order

The military cap falls into the river, breaking the razor-thin ice. The pieces chime as they float away, carrying the cap away.

He holds the rifle up. His hands are steady, but a hint of confusion lingers on his face. He can't recall when a scope has been mounted.

He looks through the scope.

Officer: Charge!

Officer: Cavalry, hold the line! Take the flank!

Black fire burns at the foot of Al Muntar. Arcane bullets scream ominously toward the men.

The attackers charge in waves, breaking against shell craters, tangling in wire, and splashing into red drops.

One wave falls. Another rises. Relentless as a rushing river against the last ice of spring.

Arseny: Andrea! What are you doing? Come on! Forward!

Arseny: You'll be shot!

A single drop stands still on the hilltop, neither advancing nor retreating.

Perun paces nervously amid the sounds of gunfire. His rider seems unaware. The loose reins drift in the blood-red waves.

Igor feels his finger on the trigger. A sharp, almost painful, kiss of cold steel.

Igor: Don't look back.

A shell bursts nearby. The horse rears up in fright.

Andrea's throat moves. He lifts his head, as if trying to locate where the fire came from.

Igor: Keep running. Don't look back.

Andrea tightens his legs around the horse's belly, leaning forward like a drawn bow. No one knows what he is thinking right now.

But Perun seems to hear something. The horse gives a long, glad whinny and turns, racing toward empty ground where there is no enemy and no comrades.

Andrea: "No man rides into the jaws of death without a reason. No man."

Andrea: "Bang!"

Igor's finger jerks on the trigger subconsciously.

clack

The rifle is empty. He has already fired his last shot. All he holds now is a shashka. The blade is rolled and chipped all along the damaged edge.

Vasily: "In close quarters, a blade is swifter than a rifle."

Igor: You were correct, Father.

At his feet lie bodies in blue uniform. Beneath them, bodies in yellow.

Foe and friend lie together, layer upon layer, a hill of the fallen.

Communicator: *buzz*

Communicator: "Admiral Igor, the files you requested regarding the Battle of Al Muntar in 1995 are not yet declassified."

Igor: And the operation's objective is above my clearance level.

Communicator: "For now, you only need to follow the order. The order is ..."

Igor: Advance. Whatever it takes.

Igor: But not this army.

Igor: Requesting use of a vacuum bomb to be deployed against Manus Vindictae lines.

Communicator: "The Pax House has determined that this weapon cannot be authorized at this moment."

Igor: Then when will the "moment" come?

The silence that follows is long and heavy.

Communicator: "There has only ever been one order."

He sees the earth form a soft wrinkle. Soldiers' bodies are extinguished in an instant like the flame of a candle.

Communicator: "We will honor every fallen soldier."

Communicator: "To cross through the chaos of the unknown, we will require your men for further experimentation."

He sees countless soldiers enter the White Stone House. They leave their faces behind, melting into pure white.

They never return. Only their names remain, row upon row upon the wall in the Hall of Merit.

Moldir: All these people ... What did they fight for? Why did they die?

Igor: I don't know, Moldir.

In the Hall, he sees his own picture, taken in his first year with Zeno.

On that day, everyone wore their dress uniforms.

They waited in line with a sorrowful sweetness for the honor that was sure to come.

Igor: I once believed in it.

Igor: I sent you to the treacherous front. I told you to advance at any price, even if the path led to the edge of the abyss or through the flames of hell.

Igor: There has only ever been one order. I thought it would bring a world of peace. I thought it would give a soldier glory that wouldn't fade.

Igor: However ... However ...

Igor feels something sharp in his palm. He opens his hand. A die lies there.

"His heart is a hanging lute, a hanging lute ... gently plucked ... "

He feels a hollow tremor. Yes, this has happened before. It will happen again. His heart was once as hard as stone.

Fate plucks the long-rusted string.

The die falls with the rain in São Paulo.

Igor: We failed to achieve glory, but I see too that glory has failed us.

Igor: Forgive me, children.

Igor: My sin is not that I stained that honor. Not that I disobeyed the White Stone House. It is that I did not stand beside you to the last.

Igor: I couldn't bring everyone into tomorrow.

Vasily: Haha! Hahahahaha!

Vasily: So brave, so stupid! Another young man destined for death.

The old, drunk cavalry commander stands in the fallen leaves with a fierce, fiery look in his eyes.

Vasily: Let me teach you the secret to winning, then.

Vasily: You must fear death, boy.

Vasily: Not just your own. You must fear the death of every man.

Igor: Their deaths are on my shoulders.

Igor: My soldiers will be with me, no matter whether they live or die.

Igor: My sins will be with me until the darkness of the underworld devours all that I am.

The old soldier smiles faintly. His calloused hand dives into his coat but finds no flask.

Vasily: Tch. Hey, little Igor. Do you remember how to hold a rifle?

Igor: Yes, Father.

Igor: First, plant the stock firmly against your shoulder. Lean back a little.

Igor's right index finger finds the trigger. He sees flakes settle on the barrel. The trigger feels cold as ice.

Igor: Steady ...

Igor: Slowly ...

Igor: Steady.

Igor: Breathe in, breathe out. At your breath's end, that is the moment.

He closes his eyes, then opens them. A figure enters his scope.

Igor: Don't look back, son.

Igor: Keep running. Don't look back.

The figure grows clear, halted between the steppe and snow, neither advancing nor retreating.

He looks a long time before he knows the man before him.

Igor: Don't look back. You must move forward, soldier.

Igor: I will not look back, nor will I follow another order.

Igor: You betrayed those who trusted you. You betrayed yourself.

Igor: I've taken another path.

Igor: Is it the right path?

The soldier and the admiral hold their distance together against the wind and snow, as Igor lets himself think the next moment through.

There has only ever been one order.

Igor: Yes, sir.

Igor: Obedient.

Igor: Loyal.

Igor: Unwavering.

His finger stays upon the trigger.

Bang!